

Creo Advisors — Discovery Meeting Question List

ENT 105 — locking objectives for an AI value-creation positioning

Purpose. Leave with a **clear, written, agreed objective** for the project (it sets ~35–40% of our grade), *and* pressure-test the direction we’ve researched — positioning Creo for the AI value-creation / “AI roll-up” wave — against what management actually wants and can credibly deliver.

Stance. This direction is our *recommendation*, not an assumption. Tier 1 tests appetite; if it’s not the fit, we adapt. **[need from Creo]** marks an input we need to build the plan.

Tier 1 — Objectives & appetite (must lock at this meeting)

1. **[need from Creo]** What do you most want from this engagement? What’s the 2027 revenue goal, and what does a “win” look like to you? (We lead with *your* objective, not ours.)
2. **[need from Creo]** How central is AI to where you want Creo to go — a direction you want to *own*, an adjacency, or not a near-term priority? Our research points to a strong opening in AI value creation; we want to confirm that fits before we build on it.
3. **Are you willing to be the contrarian, rigor-over-hype voice** — telling PE buyers what AI *can’t* durably do — in a market that’s mostly hype? The positioning depends on it.
4. **When you grade us in December, what would make this an A+?** Name the 2–3 things you most want to walk away with.

Tier 2 — Creo’s AI credibility (the make-or-break)

5. **[need from Creo]** What is Creo’s actual AI expertise and track record today? Who can credibly deliver — and speak to — AI diligence in front of a sophisticated PE buyer?
6. **[need from Creo]** Is there a genuine AI practitioner in-house, or would you acquire / partner / embed one? The “we tell you what’s real about AI” position only works if Creo is *demonstrably* real on AI — otherwise it’s the hype we’re critiquing.
7. **[need from Creo]** Are you interested in adding staff in the AI area — building genuine in-house AI capability? What’s the appetite, budget, timeline, and seniority?
8. **Build a small AI delivery team, or hire just to diligence?** Do you want to staff up to *deliver* automation, or hire only enough to *credibly assess and architect* it while vendors do the build?
9. **How would you find and vet real AI hires?** Genuine AI experts are scarce and the market is full of people overclaiming — worth applying Creo’s own “is this AI real?” rigor to its own hiring.
10. **Are you comfortable with an “orchestrate, don’t build” model** — Creo is the independent diligence-and-architecture brain; specialist vendors do the actual AI build?

Tier 3 — The offer & proof

11. **Would you offer a free “AI-Automatability Diagnostic”** as the lead magnet — and stand behind it as Creo’s signature?
12. **[need from Creo] Is there a target or portfolio company we could run a pilot diagnostic on**, for a proof case? (One real result beats any deck.)
13. **[need from Creo] What can we cite** — named clients, real outcomes — and what are the confidentiality boundaries?

Tier 4 — Distribution & the buyer

14. **[need from Creo] Which sponsors in your network are doing or seriously weighing AI roll-ups?** Which warm relationships do we lead with? (Your distribution edge over the big firms.)
15. **Who’s the economic buyer** — operating partner, deal partner, fund principal, portfolio-company CEO?
16. **What’s the biggest objection a PE buyer raises** to paying for AI diligence, and how do you answer it today?

Tier 5 — The marketing engine

17. **Would Rich lead the founder-driven LinkedIn content**, and are you up for reviving the survey motion as an annual “AI Reality Report”?
18. **Are you comfortable publishing contrarian, evidence-based takes** (e.g. “most AI pilots fail,” “the AI layoffs aren’t what they look like”)?
19. **[need from Creo] Current marketing infrastructure** — website, CRM/HubSpot, lead capture — what exists, and is there a budget for execution in 2027?

Tier 6 — Primary research access

20. **[need from Creo] Will you introduce us to 3–5 PE buyers** (sponsors / operating partners) to interview on their AI-roll-up intentions, where pilots stall, and willingness to pay?
21. **Any existing client feedback, win/loss notes, or AI-pilot data** we can start from?

Logistics to confirm before we leave

- **Primary contact & weekly cadence** — Rich, Akshita, or both? Best day/time?
- **Others to talk to internally** (e.g. Jacqueline on marketing/research)?
- **Deliverable format** for the December hand-off.
- **Next step + owner** for each open item above.

Prep notes for the team

- **Propose, don’t impose.** We’re recommending a direction; lead by understanding what management wants, test the AI appetite (Tier 1), and adapt if they want something else. The grade rides on hitting *their* objective.

- **Bring the research + draft plan as background** — surface the AI thesis as a recommendation, with the honest caveats (rigor over hype; the real handoff ratio is a map, not “1000:1”). Don’t oversell.
- Assign a **lead asker per tier** and a **note-taker**; capture the agreed objective verbatim — that wording is what we’re graded against.

Leave the meeting with one sentence both sides agree on:

“The objective of this project is to _____ (e.g. position Creo to win AI value-creation mandates and generate qualified leads via the AI-Automatability Diagnostic), measured by _____, by _____.”